much a betrayal to the pilots and airmen who flew sortie after sortie, as it was to the soldiers who had braved the conditions to prepare the defences.

Perhaps one of the reasons why Hoshiar Singh was undermined at a key juncture was the endless debate around the decision to fight at Se-la versus Bomdila. Apart from the BGS IV Corps, K. K. Singh, Anant Pathania himself was most disinclined to fight at Se-la. Kaul, ever since his reappearance, had hardly involved himself with Se-la. In fact in his version of events in *The Untold Story*, the former corps commander doesn't seem to know the difference between Se-la and Tse-la, two distinctly different passes with similarly pronounced names.

HQ IV Corps resented that Se-la as the defence line had been forced on them. That Se-la had its disadvantages was well known and in all probability, to fall back on Bomdila may have been more prudent and in keeping with the Thorat Plan of extending the Chinese lines of communication while shortening our own. But once the decision had been taken to fight at Se-la, there should have been no more debate.

Darshan Khullar, then a second lieutenant who was present at Se-la with 62 Brigade, later wrote: 'The imperative of holding Se-la should not have been in any doubt. The question is of force level and whether it should have been designated as vital ground, or a delaying position strong enough to make the Chinese redeploy and regroup for launching their offensive against the main defences around Bomdila... What it really boiled down to was "After Se-la what?" But this question was never posed or answered.'

Under the circumstances, trying to build the main divisional defences at Se-la to hold the Chinese was a flawed idea on four counts. One, it was too close to Tawang and once the road from Bum-la was constructed, logistically it became all too easy for the Chinese to start thinking of hammering away at the Se-la defences. Two, Indian troops, as Palit himself had earlier noted during his reconnaissance of Se-la, did not at that time have any experience of extreme high altitude warfare. Three, a determined enemy could invest Se-la from all sides. Again, this was a known fact but very little attention was actually paid to blocking or monitoring these routes. Four, too much importance was given to the 'winter is coming' factor. After having decided to hold Se-la on 24 October, the Indian attitude seemed to be that come end November, winter would literally freeze all aggressive options. This was way off the mark, for both Se-la and Bum-la